

CORE FORMULA

Bottom line -> key reason -> implication -> optional detail -> Bottom line: I recommend X. The reason is Y. The next step is Z. -> The main point is X; the rest is only support. -> Use the structure to organise your thinking, then speak like a person.

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Say the answer, recommendation or ask in your first sentence, add one reason, then the next step: "I recommend X. The reason is Y. The next step is Z."

BEST FOR

- Briefings and status updates
- Emails people will only skim
- Handovers
- Making a recommendation
- Urgent decisions
- Time-poor or senior audiences
- Getting to the point in a long meeting

PHRASE BANK

Quick openers · Bottom-line one-liners

- "Bottom line: we should go with X."
- "Short version: yes, with one condition."
- "Headline first — I recommend we ship on Friday."
- "The answer is no, and here's the one reason."
- "Quick one: I need a decision by three."
- "In a sentence: option B is the safer bet."
- "Short answer now, detail whenever you want it."

Meetings and briefings · Work / recommendation

- "My recommendation is X. The main reason is Y. The next step would be Z."
- "Bottom line up front: the launch is on track, with one risk to flag."
- "Where we've landed: we go with the second supplier."
- "Status in one line — green on scope, amber on timeline."
- "The decision I'm asking for is whether to approve the budget."
- "If you take one thing from this: we need to move the deadline."
- "Here's the recommendation, then the reasoning behind it."

The ask · Clear request / next step

- "What I need from you is a yes or no by Thursday."
- "The ask is simple: sign off on the revised plan."
- "Next step is yours — approve, or tell me what's missing."
- "I recommend we stop the project. Here's why."
- "One decision today: in or out."
- "The main point is X; everything else is just support."
- "Let me lead with the ask, then explain."

Written and email · Scannable messages

- "Approval needed by Friday to hold the launch date — detail below."
- "Bottom line first, background at the bottom if you want it."
- "Three lines: what I need, why, and by when."
- "I've put the ask in the first sentence so you can scan the rest."
- "Answer: yes. Reasoning follows for the record."
- "One decision, one deadline, one paragraph of context."

Brief but human · Respecting their time

- "I'll keep this short out of respect for your time."
- "Let me give you the headline first, then as much detail as you want."
- "I know you're busy, so bottom line first."
- "Here's the gist — stop me and I'll expand wherever's useful."
- "I'll lead with what matters, and you can pull on any thread."
- "Short version now, and I'm happy to go deeper whenever suits."

Checking the frame · Softening the structure

- "Let me check that's a useful way to frame it — or should we come at it differently?"
- "I can keep this short, then we adjust together."
- "Tell me if you'd rather I slow down and give the background first."
- "If the headline-first approach isn't landing, say so and I'll switch."
- "Happy to unpack any part that felt too compressed."
- "That may not be the right frame — let me back up."

Hard news, plainly · Difficult conversations

- "One sentence, then I'll pause: the project isn't going ahead."
- "I'll say the main thing plainly, then we can sit with it."
- "Here's the decision, and I want to hear your reaction before I add anything."
- "The hard part first — the answer is no. The reason matters, so let me explain."
- "I'll be direct, because you deserve a straight answer."
- "The role's being cut. I want to talk it through properly — take your time."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Announces the framework — "I'll BLUF this" — and forces every sentence into it.
Better: Uses BLUF silently to organise a concise response.
Best: Uses BLUF flexibly, then checks whether the listener is clearer and better able to respond.
2. Weak: Buries the bottom line under two minutes of background.
Better: Leads with the recommendation, then gives the reason.
Best: Leads with the recommendation and reads whether more or less detail is wanted.
3. Weak: Cuts context so hard it sounds abrupt or cold.
Better: Keeps it brief but adds one line of context.
Best: Stays brief and human — clear without sounding clipped.

DECISION TREE

If The listener needs speed

Use the shortest version — bottom line only.

"In one line: yes, do it."

If The listener needs support or is upset

Validate first and delay the framework.

"Before anything else — how are you doing with this?"

If The listener needs a story or example

Switch to an example-led neighbour such as STAR or CARL.

"Let me give you a concrete example of when this went wrong."

If The listener needs to act

End with one clean next step.

"So the next step is yours: approve or flag it by Thursday."

If The listener looks confused

Summarise and invite correction rather than pushing the structure harder.

"Let me put that a simpler way — tell me where it's not landing."

SCENARIOS

Work meeting

Lead with your contribution, then support it, so it stays concise and memorable. — "My take in one line: we should delay the launch. Here's the reason."

Email

Put the ask in the first sentence and the detail below, so it can be scanned. — "Approval needed by Friday to hold the launch date — detail below."

Giving feedback

Check what kind of feedback is wanted before you structure it. — "Want the headline, or the full walkthrough?"

Difficult conversation

One sentence per step, then pause and listen. — "The role's being cut. I want to talk it through properly — take your time."

Urgent decision

Give the recommendation and the one deciding factor, nothing else. — "Go with the backup supplier — ours can't hit the date."

Handover

State the current status, the open risk, and the single next action. — "Status: on track. Risk: the API key expires Tuesday. Next: renew it."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- Grief, loss or bad news that needs care first
- An apology or conflict repair
- Moments where listening must come before your point
- Emotionally sensitive material, shame or distress
- A power imbalance where structure could feel like pressure
- High-stakes decisions that need the human context first

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the bottom line

Take three things you need to say this week and write the single bottom-line sentence for each — the answer, not the wind-up.

Day 2 — Build the full structure

For one of them, write out all four steps: bottom line, key reason, implication, optional detail.

Day 3 — Cut by a third

Take a 60-second version and cut it by a third without losing the core point. Notice what was only support.

Day 4 — Say it two ways

Say it aloud once as a bare structure, once as plain human speech. Keep the plainer one.

Day 5 — Lead with the answer

In one real email today, put the ask or answer in the very first sentence and move the background below it.

Day 6 — Use it live, then check

In one real conversation, lead with the bottom line and watch whether the person becomes clearer or more able to act.

Day 7 — Practise the recovery

Deliberately over-structure something, then practise a recovery line that brings it back to plain, human speech.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I use BLUF to serve the listener, or to sound polished?
- Was the bottom line clear in the first sentence?
- Did I keep it concise without becoming abrupt?
- Did I adapt when the listener needed something else?
- Did I preserve the person's autonomy and dignity?
- Did the listener end up clearer, or just talked at?